# The Recruiter's Resume Checklist

25 checks to run before you hit "apply." From Christina Smith, NeoHR Consulting Group, after 20+ years of reading resumes on the hiring side.

## 1. The first 6 seconds

- [ ] **Your target title is at the top.** A headline that matches the role you want, not just your current title.
- [ ] **A 2 to 3 line summary** says what you do, for whom, and the result you are known for.
- [ ] **Contact info is current:** phone, professional email, city and state, and your LinkedIn URL.
- [ ] **No photo, date of birth, or full street address.**
- [ ] **Your most recent role is easy to find** without scrolling past a long skills list.

## 2. Experience that shows results

- [ ] **Most bullets start with a strong verb** (led, built, cut, grew, launched), not "responsible for."
- [ ] **At least half your bullets include a number:** dollars, percent, time saved, team size, volume.
- [ ] **Each recent role has 3 to 6 bullets,** ordered by impact, not by how often you did the task.
- [ ] **Older roles (10+ years) are shortened** to one or two lines or a short "Earlier experience" section.
- [ ] **Gaps are handled with a simple line** (career break, caregiving, education) instead of left unexplained.

## 3. Matched to the job

- [ ] **You have read the posting twice** and highlighted the top 5 requirements.
- [ ] **Those 5 requirements appear in your resume** using the same words the posting uses.
- [ ] **Your skills section lists tools and certifications** the role actually asks for.
- [ ] **Anything that doesn't support this target is trimmed** or moved lower.
- [ ] **Your summary is tailored** to this role or this type of role.

## 4. Built to pass applicant tracking systems

- [ ] **Simple layout:** no tables, text boxes, or graphics holding key information.
- [ ] **Standard section headings:** Summary, Experience, Education, Skills.
- [ ] **Dates in a consistent format** (Jan 2023 to Present) on every role.
- [ ] **Saved as a PDF or Word file** named FirstName-LastName-Resume.
- [ ] **Fonts are standard and readable** at 10 to 12 points.

## 5. Final polish

- [ ] **Two pages or fewer** for most professionals. Executives can go to three.
- [ ] **Read aloud once** to catch typos and awkward phrasing.
- [ ] **Consistent tense:** present tense for your current role, past tense for previous roles.
- [ ] **Your LinkedIn headline and recent titles match** the resume.
- [ ] **Someone else has read it** and could tell you, in one sentence, what job you want.

> **Recruiter tip:** if your resume is getting views but no interviews, the problem is usually the top third of page one. Rewrite your headline and summary before you change anything else.

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